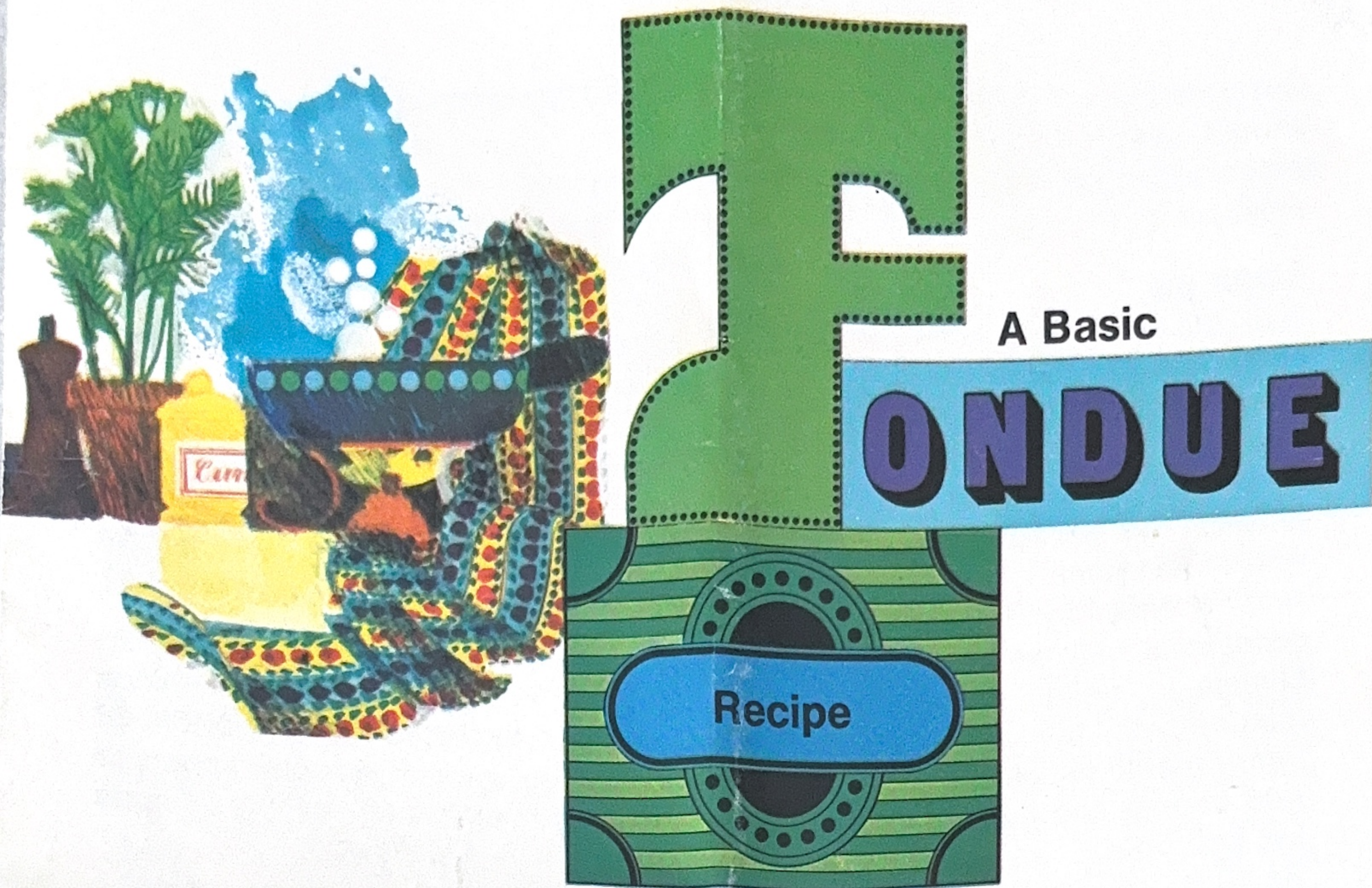




To become familiar with fondue cooking, follow this Basic Recipe. Many chefs maintain that the cook's fear of doing something wrong is transferred to the dish, therefore increasing the danger of a mishap considerably. So follow the instructions light-heartedly as an expert would.

The three basic steps of fondue cooking are:

- 1) heating the wine
- 2) adding grated cheese by handfuls, stirring constantly
- 3) letting mixture boil up

Basic Recipe for Switzerland Cheese Fondue

The following recipe will serve four persons for dinner or 12 to 20 as a

snack. Allow 15 minutes for preparation and an additional 15 minutes for cooking.

- 1 clove garlic
- 1½ cups dry white Swiss wine
- 1 tablespoon lemon juice
- 1 pound shredded Switzerland Swiss Cheese
- 3 tablespoons flour
- pepper, nutmeg to taste
- 2 loaves Italian or French bread

Preparation

Grate, shred or dice (if using pre-sliced cheese) 1 pound Switzerland Swiss Cheese. (You can do this in advance and keep cheese refrigerated in a tightly closed plastic bag.) Dredge cheese with flour.

Cut bread into 1" cubes. Each cube should have crust on one side. (If prepared in advance, keep in closed plastic bag.)

Cooking

Rub inside of pot with cut garlic clove. Discard garlic.

Place pot on stove. Pour 1½ cups of wine into pot.

Heat over medium flame until wine is warm but not boiling.

Add lemon juice.

Add cheese by handfuls, stirring constantly with wooden spoon until cheese is melted and cheese-wine mixture has the appearance of a light creamy sauce.

Add pepper and nutmeg to taste.

Let boil once.

Remove pot and put on lighted burner on top of table.

Serving and eating

Adjust flame of burner so fondue continues bubbling lightly.

Serve each guest a handful of bread cubes from bread plate or bread basket.

Spear prongs of fork through bread, crustless part first, securing prongs in crust.

Dunk and stir (!) well to bottom of pot.

Remove fork and twist over pot to remove surplus fondue on bread. Eat.

When the fondue is eaten, a crust called *la religieuse* (the religious one) will have formed on bottom of pot. Lift crust with wooden spoon or fork and distribute evenly among diners. It is a delicacy!

About Fondue in General

Fondue is a fascinating dish. It is very old, but new variations appear daily. It is simplicity itself to prepare, but there are rules that are basic to success. While there is such a thing as authentic fondue, actually there is no single "correct" fondue recipe.

Authentic Swiss Cheese Fondue is simply Switzerland cheese melted in white Swiss wine, or occasionally, some other hot liquid. In the form it is known today, it is a specialty of the French-speaking part of Switzerland. The word fondue comes from the French *fondre* which means "to melt," to dissolve. In Switzerland,

La Fondue always stands for Cheese Fondue, Switzerland cheese dissolved in white wine.

This statement leads us to the core of successful fondue cooking. Cheese contains milk fat and wine is basically water with some alcohol. Water and fat do not mix easily. To guarantee a velvety fondue, the cook must be sure to use a well-aged cheese that will melt smoothly and to select wine of the proper acidity to blend successfully. If these basic ingredients are correct, the cook will never have to face the disaster of a lumpy or stringy fondue failure.

Selecting Fondue Cheese

Switzerland Swiss Cheese was selected for our Basic Recipe for two important reasons: its mild, nut-like flavor appeals to both sophisticated and simple tastes and its long aging guarantees a smooth fondue.

However, once you have tried the Basic Recipe, you might enjoy experimenting with other cheeses suitable for fondue. In Switzerland, well-aged Emmentaler (genuine Swiss cheese) and Natural Gruyere are used separately, together, or in combination with special local cheeses.

Many years of experience have shown us that Americans usually prefer a blander fondue than the Swiss and that the cheeses listed below are the most suitable. Most are available in your supermarket, but for Appenzeller and Raclette, a cheese shop or specialty food store is your best choice.

Switzerland Swiss Cheese (Emmentaler)—the cheese with the holes; mild, nut-like flavor, chewy texture

Natural Gruyere—perhaps the most sophisticated of Switzerland's cheeses; often compared with Emmentaler, it has few holes, is notably more complex in taste and texture

Appenzeller—a smooth, firm cheese seasoned with wine and spices during its curing period

Glarus (Tilsit type)—a mellow cheese with a light and delicate flavor

Raclette—rich and creamy texture; mildly tangy taste

In selecting a cheese for fondue, remember that the flavor can only be as good as the cheese that goes into it, the texture only as smooth as the cheese is properly aged.

All Switzerland cheeses are entirely natural, with no food coloring, chemicals or preservatives added. They are made from the milk of cows fed only on fresh hay or grass, never stored or fermented grass. They are also the most imitated in the world (particularly Switzerland Swiss), so make sure you are getting the real thing by checking for the word Switzerland on the rind or label.

The following recipes are variations on the Basic Recipe using other Switzerland cheeses. The steps of the Basic Recipe apply unless otherwise mentioned. All serve four persons.

Fondue Neuchâtelaise

Use a **half-and-half mixture of Switzerland Swiss and Natural Gruyere** and a **Neuchâtel white wine**. Do *not* dredge with flour. When fondue is ready, pour **3 tablespoons Kirsch** mixed with **1 tablespoon cornstarch** into it and allow to boil for another 15 to 30 seconds.

Glarner Fondue

In *caquelon* mix $1\frac{1}{3}$ cups milk with 2 tablespoons flour, 2 tablespoons butter and a dash of salt. Cook over low heat until creamy. Add $\frac{1}{2}$ pound shredded Natural Gruyere or Glarus cheese and stir well until melted. Slowly add $\frac{1}{2}$ cup dry white wine and 4 tablespoons grated Sap Sago.

Appenzeller Fondue

Mix $\frac{1}{3}$ Appenzeller, $\frac{1}{3}$ Switzerland Swiss and $\frac{1}{3}$ Natural Gruyere.

Fondue Gruyère

For this variation, use only Natural Gruyere. First, melt 1 teaspoon butter in the *caquelon*, then brown 1 finely diced clove garlic in it. Cool *caquelon* slightly before adding wine, then proceed as in Basic Recipe.

Fondue Valaisanne

Use shredded Raclette cheese alone or in combination with Switzerland Swiss and/or Natural Gruyere.

Excerpt from LA FONDUE, a collection of authentic fondue recipes from Switzerland. Available at your favorite store or from Switzerland Cheese Association, 444 Madison Ave., New York, N. Y. 10022 at \$1.00

